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Healey hedges on public records law

Governor says ‘right exceptions’ would be key to applying measure to her office

By Matt Stout
GLOBE STAFF

Governor Maura Healey, who once vowed to bring more transparency to her office “than ever before,” said she would sign legislation subjecting her office to the state’s public records law if it had the “right exceptions in place,” and that the law

should also apply to the Massachusetts Legislature and judiciary.

Healey’s comments are among her most illustrative on expanding the Massachusetts public records law since she took office, though legislation to do just that has never reached her desk.

Massachusetts is one of just two

states where the governor’s office and Legislature are not subject to the state’s public records requirements, and it’s the only state in the country where all three major branches of government claim they are not bound to the state public records law that other government entities must follow. Healey, like past governors, has held that a 1997 state Supreme Judicial Court decision resolved that her office is not subject to the state open records

law.

In an interview with the Globe, Healey said if the Legislature sent it to her, she would sign a bill subjecting her office to the law, “depending on what it looks like and ensuring that it has the right exceptions in place.”

“Because there are important exceptions that need to be in place,” Healey said. Asked what those should be, Healey demurred, saying

HEALEY, Page A10

Boston set for fewest homicides since 1957

Mayor praises city’s ‘all-hands-on-deck effort’ to lower violent crime

By Dan Glaun, Niki Griswold, and Anjali Huynh
GLOBE STAFF

Boston is on track to end 2024 with the fewest number of homicides in nearly seven decades, mirroring a national trend of decreased violent crime and bolstering its status as one of the safest large cities in the United States.

City officials on Friday hailed the drop in killings as validation of years of work to improve policing, social services, and violence intervention outreach in the city.

“In the entire time that I’ve been a police officer, going back since when I came on, the city has never been safer, period, when it comes to crime, particularly violent crime,” Police Commissioner Michael Cox said at a news conference.

There were 24 homicides in Boston through Dec. 22, according to Boston Police data — a 33 percent decline from 2023 and the fewest in 67 years. Boston is an outlier among similarly sized US cities: In 2023, there were 150 homicides in Louisville, Ky.; 132 murders in Las Vegas; 73 homicides in Portland, Ore.; 85 in Denver; and 38 in El Paso, Texas.

Firearm violence in Boston, too, “remains at historic low levels,” Cox said, noting that 2024 saw the lowest instances of gunfire since 2011, when the city began “reliably tracking the statistics.”

CRIME, Page A6



PHOTOS BY JOHN TLUMACKI/GLOBE STAFF

Bill Giezentanner, Elissa Landre, and Lisa Standley observed birds at the Broadmoor Wildlife Sanctuary in Natick.



A male cardinal and a golden crown kinglet were among the birds sighted last week at Broadmoor as part of the Christmas Bird Count. The count is made daily from Dec. 14 to Jan. 5.



Counting bird by bird

By Chris Serres
GLOBE STAFF

Just after sunrise, in a thicket of oak trees near the banks of the Charles River, the high-pitched “tsee-tsee-tsee” calls began. Then a flash of bright yellow darted past a row of raised binoculars: a golden-crowned kinglet.

Soon, the lone bird would be joined in sound by finches, blue jays, black-capped chickadees,

Christmas tally gains urgency amid declining avian populations

white-breasted nuthatches, and tufted titmice, many in a competitive scramble to stake their turf on a frigid December morning under the snow-covered canopy of Mass Audubon’s Broadmoor Wildlife Sanctuary in Natick.

There to witness this polyphonic concert was a trio of parka-clad bird-watchers armed with binoculars and notebooks. They are among roughly 80,000 participants in a cherished winter ritual known as the Christmas Bird Count, one of the lon-

gest-running citizen science projects in the world. For avid birders, the event is the equivalent of the Super Bowl. Every day from Dec. 14 to Jan. 5, birders rise before dawn, fill canteens with coffee, and do what they do every year over the holidays: count birds.

“Our feathery friends are quite caffeinated this morning,”

BIRDS, Page A10

Clean energy industry braces for tariff effects

But taking lesson from past, some say not all will be lost if levies are added

By Ivy Scott
GLOBE STAFF

SOMERSET — The now-defunct Brayton Point power station looks like a relic from another time, a collection of aging industrial warehouses ringed by parking lots with cracked pavement and rusty chain-link fences.

Yet here is where the future of energy in Massachusetts is poised to take its next big step, as SouthCoast Wind’s offshore wind project gears up to make landfall on nearby shores, and the Prysman manufacturing company prepares to launch a new facility for the undersea power cables that will pipe in electricity from the new wind farm off the state’s southern coast.

That is, unless President-elect Donald Trump follows through on his threats to curb renewable energy and impose new tariffs that could sharply drive up costs for the imported components needed for the project. If implemented, high taxes, coupled with other economic policies, could

CLEAN ENERGY, Page A7

Fa la la blah blah

Saturday: Cloudy, drizzly. High: 39-44. Low: 37-42.

Sunday: Cloudy, rainy. High: 50-55. Low: 44-49.

High tide: 9:04 a.m. 9:44 p.m.

Sunrise: 7:13 Sunset: 4:19

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The United States saw an 18.1 percent increase in homelessness this year, a dramatic rise driven by a lack of affordable housing, natural disasters, and a surge of migrants in several parts of the country. **A2.**

A family of four from Newton were found dead at a home in Wakefield, N.H., after an apparent carbon monoxide exposure. **B1.**

Bird flu was confirmed in a noncommercial backyard flock of birds in Vermont last week. **B1.**

BioMed Realty purchased a trio of Kendall Square buildings, adding to its spate of recent acquisitions in the lab and office space sector across Greater Boston. **D1.**

Finding ways to relieve a hidden burden

For many migrants, mental health care is vital but difficult to access

By Jason Laughlin
GLOBE STAFF

There’s a phrase in Haitian Creole that describes feelings of extreme stress, anxiety, or depression that are all too common among the thousands of new migrants arriving in Massachusetts: *tet chaje*.

The literal translation is “burdened head,” a feeling of being overwhelmed. People who work with the state’s surging number of new arrivals, a majority of whom are from Haiti, hear the term often.

Migrants may accrue profound emotional injury both in their home nations, where gang violence or state-sponsored oppression are common, and through the journey to the United States. Many experience rape and assault or witness the deaths of fellow travelers.

Yet finding treatment is difficult as the state’s mental health system reels from a post-pandemic surge of anxiety, depression, and addiction. Recent migrants also face steep language and cul-

MENTAL HEALTH, Page A5



JOHN TLUMACKI/GLOBE STAFF

At Boston Health Care for the Homeless, therapist Georgia Thomas-Diaz spoke to immigrants about mental health care.